

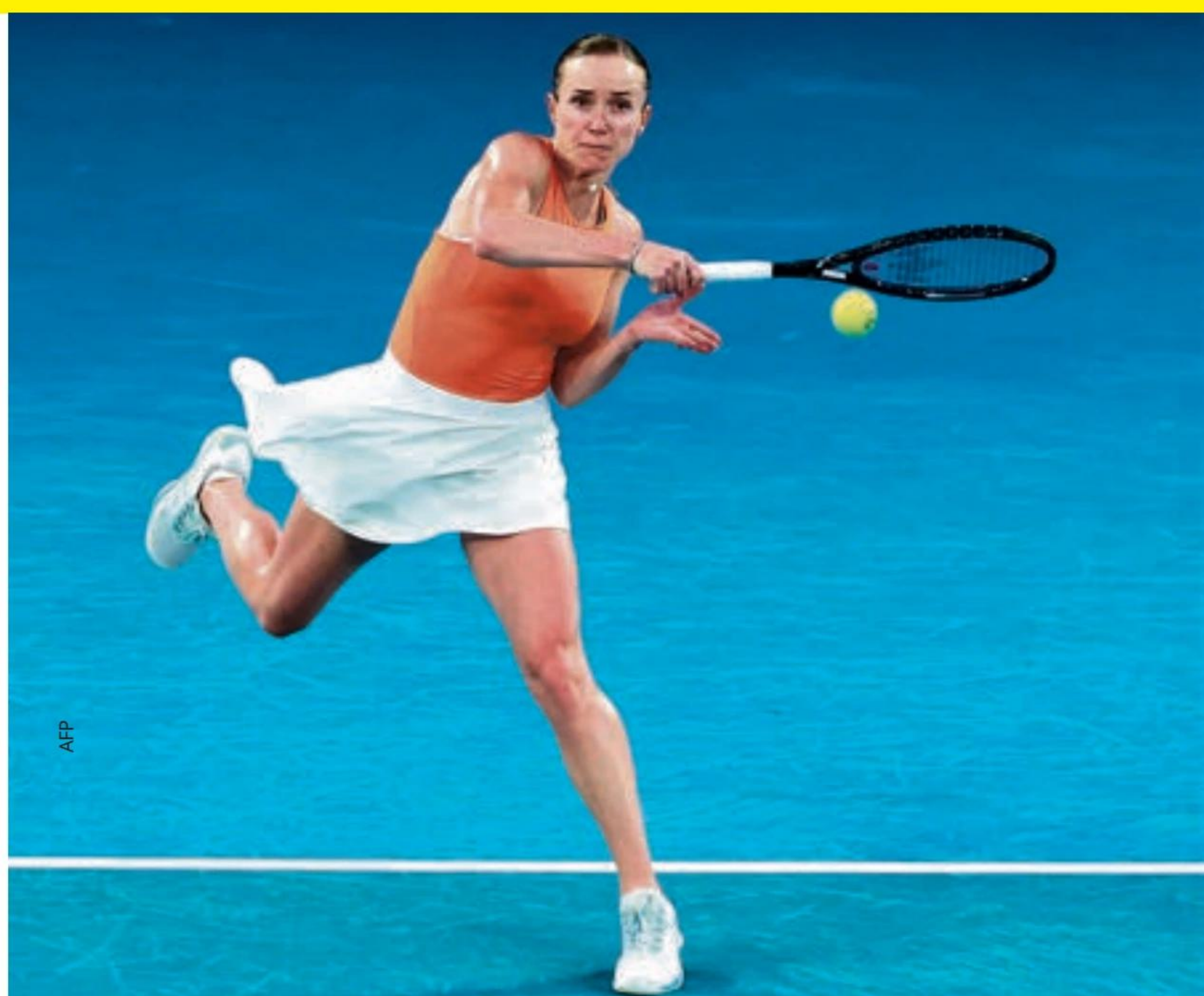
mistake by the Russian federation," said Fernandez. "They prioritised other young prospects over Rybakina for training."

Staying composed after failing to convert three break points in the second game of the must-win second set, Sabalenka found her serving groove, dictated most of the rallies, improved her positioning — 23 per cent inside the baseline compared to only 14 per cent in the first — and grabbed a 5-4 lead. The constant pressure paid off as Rybakina finally blinked. Sabalenka broke serve at love to seize the set, 6-4, thanks to three unforced errors and her forehand winner.

Their second Australian Open final followed almost the same score pattern as the first in 2023, when Sabalenka prevailed 4-6, 6-3, 6-4 for her first Grand Slam title. Would history repeat itself? Would Rybakina's once-dodgy forehand hold up? Would Sabalenka suffer another meltdown? Would Rybakina reverse her mediocre 9-14 record in three-set matches at Majors? Would Sabalenka sustain her momentum in the deciding set?

The Belarusian answered the last question by streaking to a 3-0 lead. When she climaxed a furious 16-shot exchange to earn a break in the second game with a backhand winner, Fernandez said, "This is power tennis at its absolute best!" A backhand serve return winner on the next point got the critical service break. "There's no energy. Let's go. You need more energy," beseeched coach Vukov with Rybakina trailing 3-0, 30-all. She reignited her game with renewed energy, more power on her shots and more accuracy on her serves. She reversed the momentum with two service breaks to surge ahead 4-3.

The frustration was finally getting to Sabalenka. With Rybakina ahead 4-3, 30-15, Sabalenka belted a backhand that landed two inches wide. Sensing she had squandered her last chance, she bounced her racquet on the hard court more in resignation than anger, hardly the self-flagellation or racquet-smashing of past meltdowns. Rybakina held



serve for 5-3 and Sabalenka settled down to easily hold for 5-4.

With steel nerves and explosive power, Rybakina belted two 86-mph forehand winners to lead 30-15. Sabalenka responded with a gutsy backhand service return winner down the line for 30-all. Rybakina's serve ruled two last times: a 117-mph blast that overpowered Sabalenka's backhand for championship point, and a wicked slice for an ace.

Game, set and title: 6-4, 4-6, 6-4 for Rybakina.

The stoical champion indulged in a smile. "It's so nice to see joy on that young lady's face," said Evert.

Sabalenka covered her face under a towel as she tasted yet another bitter defeat. Afterwards, she philosophised, "Today you're loser; tomorrow you're winner. Hopefully I'll be more of a winner this season than a loser."

Ironically, the Belarusian had the right mentality but the wrong tactics. "Sabalenka didn't do her homework. She didn't position herself wider on returns to cover Rybakina's wide serve," said Navratilova. "She used the body serve only once, and Rybakina couldn't handle it. She lost the match more with her [flawed] shot selection

and strategy." In a compliment to both stars, Navratilova added, "This was the best Sabalenka played and still lost." But much credit must go to Rybakina. She became the first WTA player in history to defeat the No. 1 and No. 2 in consecutive tournaments. Although Rybakina and Sabalenka won the same number of total points, 92, the champion won more of the big ones. "I always believed that I [could] come back to the level I was," said Rybakina. "Of course, we all have ups and downs. I think everyone thought maybe I will never be again in the final or even get a trophy, but it's all about the work. When you get some wins, big wins against top players, then you start to believe more. You get more confident. That was the kind of way."

Five different women — Rybakina, Sabalenka, Swiatek, Gauff and Keys — have captured the most recent Majors. They, and contenders young and old like Andreeva, Mboko, Anisimova, Linda Noskova, Karolina Muchova and Pegula, could crash the party at the remaining Majors and 1000 events. Even so, Navratilova likes Rybakina's chances. "She's a complete player," said Navratilova. "She could go to No. 1."